SWEET TART DOUGH

MAKES	ACTIVE TIME	REST	TOTAL TIME
4 tart shells, 23 cm, or 12 tartlet shells at 10 cm	**15 min**	**2 h chilled minimum or overnight, then 15 min once lined**	**about 2 h 45 min**

OVEN

325F / 160C, 7 to 10 min partially baked, 5 min longer for fully baked

INGREDIENTS

255 g	Unsalted butter, at room temperature
200 g	Sugar
1/4 tsp	Salt
2	Eggs, large, at room temperature
500 g	All-purpose flour
1	Egg, large, for the wash
a pinch	Salt, for the wash

METHOD

1. Paddle the butter, sugar and salt together in a stand mixer on medium until the mixture is smooth.
2. Beat in one egg, then the second, and keep going until it is smooth again.
3. Stop the mixer and scrape the bowl down with a rubber spatula.
4. Tip in all the flour at once and run the mixer on low only until it disappears into the dough.
5. On a lightly floured bench, divide the dough into four equal balls and flatten each into a disk 12 mm thick. Wrap tightly and chill at least 2 hours, or overnight.
6. To line a pan, roll a disk out to 3 mm on a lightly floured surface, working from the middle outward in every direction. Lift the sheet and swing it a quarter turn every few passes, dusting underneath when it starts to grab, and move fast so it does not warm up.
7. Cut a circle 5 cm wider than the pan.
8. While the dough is still cool, lay the circle in the pan, settle it into the bottom and up the sides, and press it home gently. Never pull it to fit, because stretched sides shrink back during the bake.
9. If the dough has gone too soft to handle, give it a few minutes in the fridge before you transfer it.
10. Patch any tear with a scrap of dough, pressing firmly so it sticks. With a sharp knife, trim the edge flush with the rim of the pan.
11. Put the lined shell in the fridge or freezer until firm, about 15 minutes.
12. For tartlets, roll the dough the same way, cut circles to suit your pans and line them. Freeze what is left over, scraps included.
13. Heat the oven to 325F. Prick the base of the shell all over with fork tines or a knife tip, tiny holes about 5 cm apart.
14. Bake a large shell 7 to 10 minutes for partially baked, or tartlet shells 5 to 7 minutes. It should look dry and matte with only a little color. Check during the bake and turn the pans if one side is coloring faster.
15. To seal the shell with egg wash, beat the egg with a pinch of salt. A minute or two short of the color you want, pull the shell out, brush the base and sides thinly, then return it until the color arrives and the coating has set.
16. For a fully baked shell, carry on as above but give it about 5 minutes more, to golden brown.
17. Cool the shells completely on wire racks.

NOTES

Egg wash brushed on the inside of a partially baked shell seals the pastry and keeps the crust crisp longer under a wet filling.
An easy dough to work. It rolls very thin, holds its shape instead of slumping down the pan, and takes being re-rolled several times without going tough.
To get eggs to room temperature fast, sit them in a bowl under running lukewarm water for about 5 minutes.
Leftover dough bakes off as a plain cookie dough.

PRESERVING

This dough keeps exceptionally well, so it is worth mixing a full batch and banking most of it as ready-to-roll disks.
Wrapped disks need 2 hours in the fridge at minimum and hold overnight.
Frozen, the wrapped disks keep up to 1 month and roll out straight after thawing.
Scraps and offcuts freeze alongside the disks and bake as cookies later.
Baked shells keep well wrapped for 1 week refrigerated or 2 weeks frozen.